

The Final Chapters

Elyssa's mind was still reeling from the quick departure. Since she and Kira had returned to their home, life had been somewhat peaceful. Disturbingly so. They'd passed their days cleaning the tower and the yard, reorganizing and resupplying the house, recoiling at every sudden noise or dark shadow, and holding each other tight every time one of them slept, with as many defenses around their room and their home as they could muster. They couldn't even sleep anymore without lights in every corner of the room. Yet, despite the fear... nothing had happened. The Horrors hadn't come for them, and nothing else had caused a problem. Everything had been going smoothly.

And then Aya called.

They had been really happy to hear from her, of course. She talked about how she'd been on some adventures, how she'd upgraded Dave and even met her Uncle Utron. And when she mentioned that now they were trying to figure out a neutral place to hold a critical meeting, Kira and Elyssa had immediately offered to host it. After all, they wanted to help, however they could. This meant risking their peace and getting back into the action—something they accepted readily. The peace had been stifling anyway.

The delegation had been more than Elyssa could have anticipated. Representatives of every major power, along with their respective ships and guards, had surrounded their little island of peace. She'd done what she could to welcome them in and provide for them, but these were some of the most important people in the galaxy. If something was going to go wrong, this would be where. So she and Kira had made sure, just in case, to pack some bags. One each, just essentials—some clothes, travel supplies, a few small irreplaceable pieces of family history.

The moment Aya tore into the room, Elyssa and Kira knew something was up. No discussion was needed, they just grabbed their bags and ran, out to the Starwasp. As they got to the yard, they froze; Kira crumpled to her knees. In the distance, and rapidly approaching, was the largest fleet they'd ever seen. They knew how massive the forces of the Clockwork Horrors were, but seeing just a fraction of their power, descending upon their home...

Aya immediately pulled Kira up to her feet, urging the two of them to hurry. She rushed them into the ship, then ran into the yard to onboard as many other people as they could fit. There would only be enough time for one trip, and Elyssa knew that Aya wanted to save as many people as she could. An eternity of moments later, Aya bolted to the pilot's seat and launched the craft unceremoniously towards the Starcutter. Once aboard, she didn't even wait to get everyone off—Aya immediately ran off to meet with her crew and make sure the escape was as successful as possible.

While most of the refugees were ushered off, Elyssa and Kira were somewhat familiar with the ship already; the two of them had made their way back to their room, where they'd stayed the last time they were on the ship. Elyssa's head was pounding; she couldn't get the image of that fleet out of her mind. This was at least the third time the Horrors had invaded their home; with a fleet that size, there was no way they were going to let it stay standing. Elyssa's heart broke as tears began to force their way to the surface. Their family home was almost definitely razed to the ground by now. The

last monument to their years of peace as a family, reduced to nothing but rubble and the echoes of lost memories.

And that flagship... It haunted her. She could tell, just from those brief moments when it had seared itself into her memory. It was like this ship, but made for war. If it worked like it looked, then they were all still in danger. The Horrors would pursue them as long as necessary, and they'd have the firepower to kill every last person on this vessel, and there was nothing she could do about it.

It was the waiting that was the hardest. Knowing that they were being hunted, all Kira and Elyssa could do was sit in silence on the bed, holding each other's hands, and wait. It seemed like hours had passed—or it could have only been a few minutes—before a knock on the door made them jump.

"Mama? *Amme*? Can I come in?" Aya's metallic voice rang out from the other side, soothing the pair's nerves.

"Of course, sweetie." Elyssa's voice wavered slightly as she recovered from the sudden scare. The door opened, and the familiar form of their daughter appeared in the doorway. Elyssa and Kira ran over to her and wrapped her in a hug before pulling her into their room.

"We're so happy you're alright, Aya. What with the fleet and all those uneasy people out there, anything could have happened. Is there anything we can do to help?" Elyssa nodded along in agreement with her wife.

"Actually, there is something you can do. The meeting ended well; all the major powers have agreed to offer their assistance to fight the Clockwork Horrors. However, we are currently being followed by their flagship, a spelljammer of nearly equal ability to the Starcutter." Elyssa nodded; it was just as she had guessed. "We have a plan for dealing with it, one that could prove to be a key swinging point in the war efforts if we succeed. In order to carry this task out, however, we need to understand how to use a magical artifact we have procured during our adventures. I have a few others helping me analyze it, but I was really hoping you two could also help. There's no one else who I would trust more on this than you."

Elyssa gripped her wife's hand and looked her in the eyes; Kira gave a nod in response.

"Lead the way, sweetie."

Many hours later, Aya's scavenged group of experts had figured out how the ancient Asrian device worked. In truth, most of them hadn't been able to contribute much, but collectively, they'd been able to work together far more effectively than probably anyone could have done on their own.

Now, Aya's adventuring crew was standing in an isolated room, out of the way from where the other passengers might stumble into them. Alongside Aya, there was the Changeling Nylos, the Hadozee Miji, and two constructs. One of them was an unfamiliar construct, made entirely of stone and magic on the spot to accompany Aya's crew on a boarding mission. The other, however... she could only assume he was Dave. This new form was still clearly made from Clockwork pieces, but it was

also something new. Resembling a mechanical centaur, if the horse half were more of an insect, he was clearly more intimidating than before. And yet, despite that, Elyssa felt... less scared. Maybe she was starting to heal, maybe his silhouette was just different enough to not trigger her memories, or maybe she was just too focused on helping right now to process her emotions, but she wasn't shaken enough that she couldn't do her duty.

Aya had asked her to operate the device, to be the one sending her off, and there was no chance that Elyssa would do that and show her daughter her fear. She looked over at the group to check if they were ready as the ship dropped out of spelljamming speed. Aya gave her a thumbs-up.

With that, Elyssa closed her eyes and focused on the device, pouring magical energy into it. It took a little time to open the teleportation circle, but their slight speed advantage had bought enough time to finish the activation ritual and still have some time left over. As they got the word that the Clockwork Flagship was in position, Elyssa looked over to her daughter again.

"Come home safe, sweetie. Good luck." With that, the group headed through the portal.

It was difficult to tell how long it was before they returned—bloodied, bruised, and absolutely battered, but alive. The stone construct was nowhere to be seen, presumably destroyed in the line of duty. As Aya came through, Elyssa wrapped her in a big hug.

"I'm home, Mama." The little construct wrapped her arms around her mom and held her lightly—it was clear she was exhausted and shaken, but she was *alive*, and that was the most important thing. "Can I come talk to you and *Amme* later? We need to go let the others know what happened, but it was a total success."

"Of course, sweetie. We'll be waiting for you; come by whenever you're ready. Go do what you need to." As Aya stepped back to follow her companions out of the room, she somewhat dragged behind; she clearly had something on her mind. And as she left the room, out of the corner of her eye, Elyssa could swear she saw something move. She spun to look at it, but there was nothing there, as though it had just... blinked out of existence. Either that, or she was jumping at shadows again. The latter was more likely; she shook her head, trying to clear her thoughts and went back to meet Kira in their room.

Kira grilled her the moment she got back; she wanted to know *everything* that had happened, even though Elyssa didn't have all the details. She explained that it was a success and described all the details she could about Aya's injuries and behavior when she'd returned. There wasn't much she could say; Aya hadn't been very forthcoming at the time, but she'd probably tell them all about it when she came back.

The wait for Aya's return couldn't have been more than thirty minutes, but it still felt too long before their daughter arrived. She was still dragging as she moved, as though she were carrying too much weight, but otherwise seemed relatively healthy—at least, she was in better shape physically than her companions had been. Kira wrapped her up tightly in a hug; Elyssa let her have this one, since she'd already gotten one when Aya first got back from the flagship.

“Mama, *Amme*, would it be alright if I brought Dave in too? I worked with him to try to make him less scary, and I don’t think he’ll cause as many issues now. I just... I really want to be with my whole family right now.” Elyssa looked over at her wife and gave her a nod, trying to reassure her. Kira had been much worse after they’d escaped from the Horrors, so she might have a stronger reaction to their grandson’s new appearance, but this was really important to Aya. Kira stepped back and squeezed Elyssa’s hand tightly, then gave a nod of approval. Aya’s shoulders lifted some, though she still seemed upset as she ran off to get her son. It only took a few moments for the two of them to return; Dave clearly hadn’t been far off.

As Dave entered the room, Kira’s hand bit into Elyssa’s. She was trying to hold it in, but his appearance still triggered something in her. Elyssa rubbed her wife’s hand, trying to reassure her. Now that their situation was less tense, Elyssa could get a better look at Dave. He was tall now—much taller than he’d been before, probably about 5 and a half feet tall. His hands had clunky digits, almost charming in their unwieldiness, and his head was more of, well, an actual head now, with two eyes and antennas for ears and a neck and everything. He was much more... humanoid. Still clearly a machine, but also clearly a person. Just like Aya, but a bit... stranger.

Elyssa pulled Kira down to sit on the bed, then pried her hand away for a moment. She walked over to Dave—as she got closer and the height difference got larger, she noticed that his lower body was much more reminiscent of a base Clockwork unit and began to freeze, but she’d made up her mind on this and forced herself to follow through. Eyes squeezed shut to block out her vision, she reached up and pulled Dave into a hug. She jumped slightly as he returned the gesture.

With a shaky voice, she forced out the only sentence she could think of in his arms: “Welcome to the family, Dave.”

As she shuffled back to the bed to sit beside her wife and grab her hand, Elyssa noticed that Aya lit up briefly before sinking back down. Kira also must have noticed it, since she spoke up before Elyssa could.

“Aya? Is something the matter? You seem to have something else on your mind.” The autognome paused as she thought about what to say; for a moment, she started to say something, before stopping herself. Then she did it again. And again. Elyssa thought she caught a part of the word “forgive” in there, but it was hard to tell. Frustrated, their little girl gave up and leapt onto the bed, wrapping her parents into her arms as tightly as she could; she was *clearly* shaking. If Aya was physically capable of crying, Elyssa was sure she would be sobbing.

“I... I’m sorry! I’m so, so sorry!”

“Hey, it’s okay. You’re alright. Everything’s gonna be alright.” Elyssa had no idea what could have shaken her daughter so much, but she would do or say anything to help her.

“It’s not alright! I almost threw my life away! I just... wanted to help everyone. To do everything I could to help. And I rushed and took a stupid risk that I didn’t need to and I could have died, and I didn’t even try to fight back!” Aya buried herself deeper into her parents’ arms.

“Aya, sweetie.” Kira reached an arm up and rubbed Aya on the head. “We’re not mad at you. It sounds like you’re mad at yourself, and that’s a good thing. It means you care about living; you feel

guilty about gambling with your life, and you want to live, to keep fighting. Today, you took a risk; that's what all adventurers do when they go out and fight, when they strive to make the galaxy a better place. We *know* you, Aya. If you took a chance on something, then you had a good reason. We trust you; both Mama and I, but also your other friends. These are dark times—possibly the darkest there's ever been. We all have to take risks, but honestly, sweetie?" Aya looked up at her mother's face. "It makes me happy to hear you're so upset. I can feel just a little bit better, knowing that you're going to fight like hell to make sure you come back to us at the end of this all."

Elyssa nodded in agreement. "At the end of the day, the most important thing isn't *what* you did. It's that you made it out to deal with its consequences another day. And as long as you keep making it back home, we could never be mad at you. We love you, Aya." Aya pulled back some to look at both her parents.

"I love you too, Mama. *Amme*." Kira looked down at their daughter for a second, thinking, before she spoke up again.

"You know, Aya, it's been awhile since all got to really talk like this. You've got a lot to catch us up on. Why don't you stay with us for a bit? We can spend the night talking together until you feel better, just like old times."

Aya nodded her head.

"That sounds nice."